Reimagining the Virtual School Head Title: Executive Summary

Overview

This report recommends changing the title "Virtual School Head" to **"Headteacher for Children's Social Care"** based on comprehensive research including survey responses from 135 professionals, document analysis, and evaluation of alternatives against key criteria.

Key Issues with Current Title

The current "Virtual School Head" title presents significant challenges:

1. **Misunderstanding of "Virtual"**: The term is widely misinterpreted as meaning an online or digital school, causing confusion among stakeholders.
2. **Frequent Need for Explanation**: 72% of surveyed professionals report they "very frequently" have to explain their title to colleagues, schools, families, and children.
3. **Limited Reflection of Expanded Role**: The title doesn't reflect how the role has evolved to include previously looked-after children, children with social workers, and (from September 2024) children in kinship care.
4. **Lack of Clarity About Function**: The title fails to communicate the strategic leadership aspect of the role and its position at the intersection of education and social care.
5. **Perception and Status Issues**: The ambiguity undermines the authority of the role and creates barriers to effective collaboration.

Recommendation

We recommend changing the title to:

Headteacher for Children's Social Care

This recommendation is based on:

- **Survey Results**: 69% of respondents rated changing the title as "Extremely important" or "Somewhat important"
- **Evaluation**: This title scored highest (29/35) across criteria including clarity, accuracy, inclusivity, authority, and simplicity
- **Strategic Positioning**: It positions the role at the intersection of education and social care systems
- **Stakeholder Preferences**: It maintains the valued "Headteacher" element while eliminating the problematic "Virtual" term

Rationale

The recommended title:

- **Eliminates "Virtual"**: Removes the most problematic term that causes confusion
- **Maintains Authority**: Preserves the valued "Headteacher" element that conveys seniority
- **Clarifies Function**: Explicitly connects education leadership with social care
- **Reduces Need for Explanation**: Is more intuitive and self-explanatory
- **Reflects Evolution**: Acknowledges the expanded scope of the role
- **Provides Longevity**: Should remain relevant even as specific populations served may change

Alternative Consideration

"Head of Education for Care-Experienced Children" emerged as an equally strong alternative (also scoring 29/35) and would be appropriate if stakeholders prefer: - More emphasis on the educational aspect of the role - Person-centered language - Less explicit connection to social care systems

Implementation Recommendations

1. **Timing**: Align with the release of new statutory guidance
2. **Stakeholder Engagement**: Form a national working group of Virtual School Heads and key stakeholders
3. **Documentation**: Update statutory guidance, local authority documentation, job descriptions, and online resources
4. **Transition**: Implement a defined transition period where both titles are used

Conclusion

The recommended title change represents more than simple rebranding—it is an opportunity to clarify the purpose and importance of this vital role, enhancing understanding and support across education, social care, and the wider community.

This change will help professionals spend less time explaining their title and more time focusing on improving educational outcomes for some of the most vulnerable children in our society.